

2, Giving Civilization to the Years, Not Years to Civilization

Thus, before the end of 2022, I evidently confirmed an exceedingly sorrowful conclusion. However, discovering these things clearly cannot allow a person's thoughts to linger merely at the level of grief. According to general observation, when people receive a relatively immense shock, they will further seek solace.

On the eve of the winter vacation, I found myself involuntarily pondering certain questions. I realized that Chinese people place far too much emphasis on possessing a "long history." We always pretend not to know that civilizations will perish, just as we vehemently taboo the topic of death in everyday life.

Now, I believe this is wrong. Just as the verses written about the execution of Taira no Atsumori (平敦盛) in *The Tale of the Heike* (《平家物语》) state: "*Once one attains life, who can avoid the fate of perishing!*" ("一度得生者，谁能不灭哉！")

Modern cosmology even posits that the universe might expand infinitely. When entropy (熵) increases to its absolute limit, let alone matter, even time itself can no longer be said to exist. What reason, then, is there to believe that the achievements created by humanity will continue eternally?

Obviously, Chinese philosophy in the past—if the simplistic thinking of our country's scholars could even be called philosophy—rarely considered this question seriously. If anything could compel the Chinese to consider it, it was probably Buddhism introduced from India. However, as the Buddhist organizations were severely dismantled during the restoration of the **bureaucratic state**, its ideologies vulgarized accordingly. By the Yuan, Ming, and Qing dynasties, this question seemed to have entirely faded from people's field of vision.

Therefore, I profoundly admire the philosophers of the Western classical era. The Roman Emperor Marcus Aurelius pondered this issue in his *Meditations*. Even earlier, the Homeric epics proclaimed: "*For in my heart and soul I know this well: the day will come when sacred Troy must die, Priam must die and all his people with him.*"

When the renowned Roman general Scipio Aemilianus (小西庇阿 / Scipio Africanus the Younger) stood upon the ruins of Carthage after annihilating the enemy state, he too felt a deep sense of melancholy and recited that exact line from the *Iliad*. He deeply understood that "all good things must come to an end" (天下没有不散的筵席). Rome had defeated its formidable foe, but even Rome could not exist eternally.

It is precisely because of this incident that Scipio Aemilianus became one of my favorite illustrious generals. I believe that even as a general, one is inherently a human being first. The formidable cognitive capability—especially the introspection (内省)—demonstrated by Scipio Aemilianus is precisely what the so-called illustrious generals of ancient China lacked.

In fact, I believe that apart from a very few exceptions like Han Xin (韩信), those so-called Chinese illustrious generals were exactly what Liu Bang called them: "*meritorious hounds*" (功狗). It is true they were skilled in battle, but *why* were they fighting? What should be done *after* the battle? Where lay the meaning of their own lives? They rarely pondered these questions, or were incapable of pondering them. Therefore, they could only serve as the capable hunting dogs of the emperor.

Returning to the main point: when I reflect upon the histories of the East and the West, I feel deeply that we have walked down a completely erroneous path (from a philosophical perspective).

Many civilizations were born in Western history and no longer exist today: Crete, Mycenae, ancient Greece, and ancient Rome—they have all become part of history. But civilization is like a dandelion (蒲公英). A single dandelion cannot live forever, but its seeds can be carried by the wind to distant lands, taking root and blooming into new flowers.

Has the original dandelion truly disappeared completely? Can the modern Western world truly find no trace of ancient Greece and Rome today? Obviously not.

The rise and fall of civilizations, much like the metabolism of human affairs, is undeniably an unstoppable force. But this does not mean the history written by every civilization is nihilistic (虚无的). During the time it existed, it may have birthed magnificent philosophies, created phenomenal inventions, or pushed local society massively forward. These enterprises will ultimately not be obliterated; as a legacy, they will become the cornerstones for the establishment of new civilizations, and posterity will be happier because of them. **This is where the meaning of civilization lies, and people should accept this fact with tranquility.**

This is exactly why I adore the ancient Sumerian epic, the *Epic of Gilgamesh*. When Gilgamesh endured untold hardships to seek the path to immortality, the answer he ultimately received was this: Although he, as a king, could not live forever, he could absolutely make his life extraordinarily meaningful—and the path to doing so was by building his state and treating his people well.

If the Sumerians of forty centuries ago pondered these questions and arrived at their own answers, then the Chinese today should consider this even more seriously.

Chinese people constantly boast about their civilization and the incredibly long years it has endured, but what exactly has it left for the world? It once possessed one-fourth of the world's population; did it create scientific and cultural achievements commensurate with its colossal mass? When people thousands of years from now recall this country, will the only thing that comes to mind be that it slid pathetically toward its doom along a bureaucratic track for over a millennium?

It is just like a human being. I believe that by these recent centuries, it is very difficult to call my motherland "alive." **Does it not resemble a zombie (僵尸)?** A creation that can still move, yet harbors no beneficial thoughts, capable only of inflicting colossal destruction. If a person turns into a zombie, are they still considered alive? Even if considered alive, how much meaning is there in it?

"Give civilization to the years, do not give years to civilization" (要给岁月以文明，不是要给文明与岁月). When I recently met my friend S, he spoke this sentence to me, and I agreed with him profoundly.

2, 给岁月以文明, 并非给文明以岁月

就这样, 我在 2022 年结束之前显然确认了一个令人感到非常悲哀的结论, 但是显然发现这些并不能让人的思想仅仅停留到哀伤这个层面。根据一般的观察, 当人们受到某种比较大的刺激的时候就会进一步地寻求宽慰。我在寒假前夕便不自主地思考一些问题, 我意识到中国人实在是太过强调历史悠久, 我们总是假装不知道文明是会消亡的, 就跟在生活中对于死亡十分避讳一样。现在我认为这是错的, 正如《平家物语》里面平敦盛被杀一段所写下的诗句“一度得生者, 谁能不灭哉! ”。现代的宇宙学甚至认为宇宙可能会无限的膨胀下去, 当熵已经增加到极限的时候, 不要说物质, 甚至连时间本身也不能说存

在了，那么有什么理由认为人类所创造的成果会永远延续下去呢？很显然，过去中国的哲学，如果说我国学者们那样简单的思考能称得上哲学的话，很少认真思考这个问题。如果说有什么能够让中国人去考虑它，那大概是从印度传来的佛教，然而随着佛教在官僚国家复辟的过程中其组织被严重破坏，思想随之庸俗化，到元明清的时候这个问题似乎已经从人们的视野中淡出了。

因此我非常佩服西方古典时代的哲学家，罗马皇帝马可奥勒留在《沉思录》中就思考这一问题，更早的荷马史诗里面也写道“可是我的心和灵魂也清清楚楚地知道：有朝一日，这神圣的特洛伊和普里阿摩斯，还有普里阿摩斯挥舞长矛的人民，都将灭亡”，罗马名将小西庇阿在灭亡迦太基之后站在敌国的废墟上也感到怅然，吟诵了《伊利亚特》中的那一句诗，他深知天下没有不散的筵席，罗马击败了自己的强敌，但是即使是罗马也不可能永远存在下去。也就是因为这件事，小西庇阿成为我最喜欢的名将之一，我认为即使身为将军本身也是人，小西庇阿所展现的强大的认知能力特别是内省恰恰是中国古代名将所缺少的。实际上，我认为除了极少数人，比如韩信以外所谓中国的那些名将也不过是刘邦所说的功狗罢了，能征善战不假，为什么打仗，打完之后要怎么样，自己人生的意义在何处，他们很少去思考这些问题，或者不能思考这些问题，因而只能作为皇帝的得力猎犬。

话说回来，当我思考东方和西方的历史，我深感我们走在了一条错误的道路上（从哲学的层面来说）。西方历史上诞生过很多文明，现在都已经不复存在，克里特，迈锡尼，古希腊和古罗马，他们已经成为历史的一部分。但是文明就如同蒲公英一样，一株蒲公英不可能永远活下去，但是蒲公英的种子能够随风飘到远方，继而扎根长出新的花朵。原有的蒲公英真的完全消失了吗？今天的西方世界真的见不到一点古代希腊和罗马的影子吗？显然不是这样。文明的兴亡应当如同人事代谢一样，固然是不可阻挡之事，但是这不代表每个文明所书写的历史是虚无的，在它所存在的时光里，或者诞生了伟大的思想，或者创造了了不起的发明，或者把当地的社会阶段向前推了一大步。这些事业终将不会湮没，它们作为遗产将成为新的文明建立的基石，而后人因此更加幸福，文明的意义就在于此，人们应该坦然地接受这一事实。

这就是我为什么非常喜欢古代苏美尔史诗《吉尔伽美什》的原因，当吉尔伽美什费尽千辛万苦去寻找永生之道，他最终获得的答案是，自己作为国王虽然不能够永世长存，但是他完全可以让自己的生命变得更加意义非凡，而途径就是建设自己的国家并善待自己的人民。如果四十个世纪前的苏美尔人就思考过这些问题，并且有了自己的答案，那么今天中国人就更应该认真思考这一点。中国人总是夸耀自己的文明，历经了多么漫长的岁月，但是它又为世界留下了什么呢？它曾经拥有全世界 1/4 的人口，有创造出与其体量相匹配的科学文化吗？难道当千百年后人们回忆起这个国家，想到的只是他在一千多年的时间里沿着官僚化轨道可悲地滑向尽头？这就好比人一样，我认为等到最近几个世纪的时候，我的祖国已经很难称得上是“活着的”了，它难道不像一个僵尸吗？一个仍然能活动，但是却没有任何有益的思想，仅仅能造成巨大破坏的造物。如果一个人变成僵尸，那么他还算活着吗？就算认为他活着，这又有多少意义呢？要给岁月以文明，不是要给文明与岁月，前次与友人 S 相见，他那时对我谈到这句话，我深以为然。